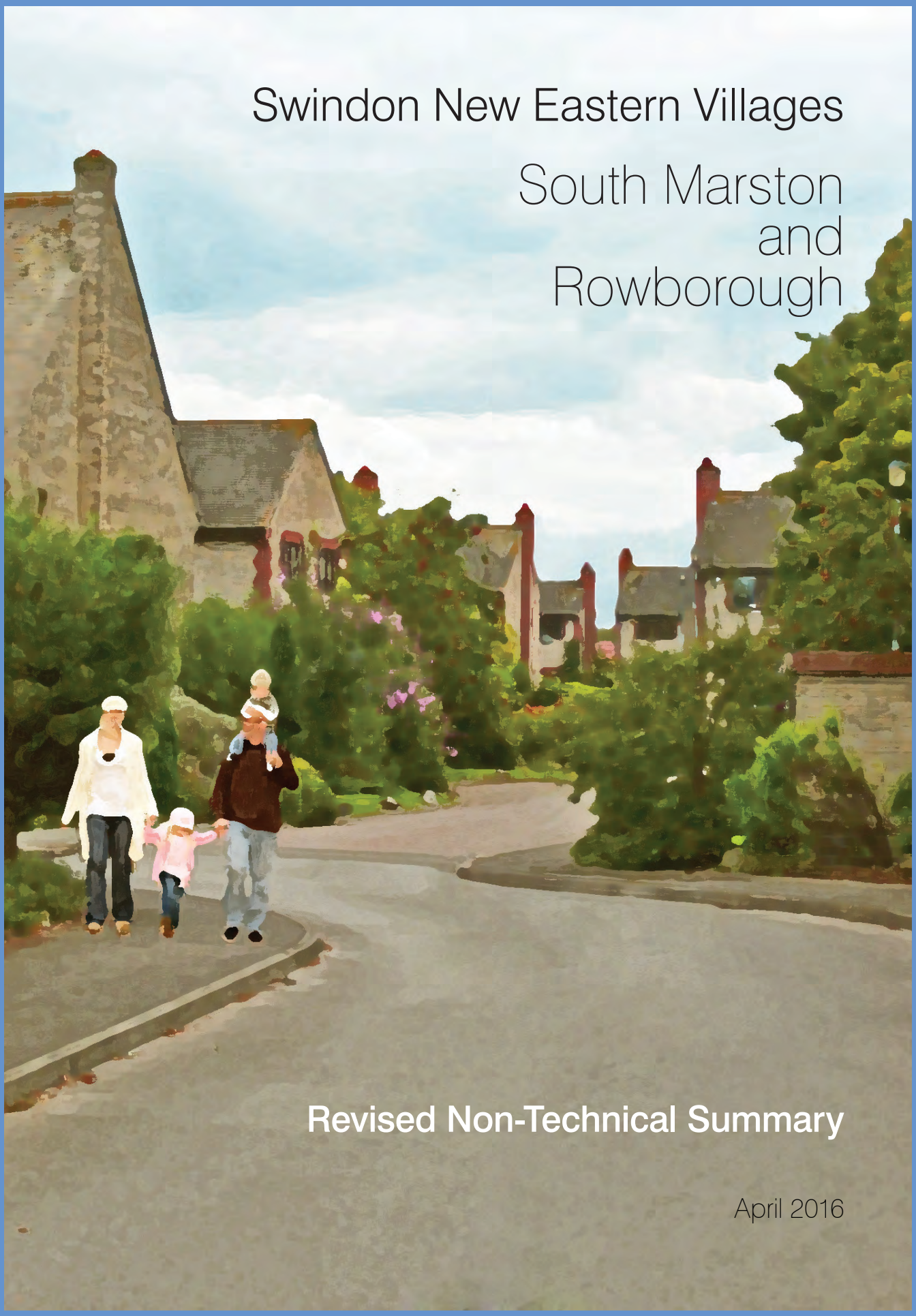
Swindon New Eastern Villages

South Marston and Rowborough



Revised Non-Technical Summary

April 2016

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01 Introduction

1.1 This document summarises the findings of an Environmental Impact Assessment (EIA) of a proposed eastern expansion of Swindon. The following plan shows the location and the detailed boundary of the Proposed Development.

1.2 The purpose of an EIA is to assess the likely significant environmental effects of a development proposal. These effects have been assessed as "adverse" or "beneficial"; and of "major", "moderate", "minor" or "negligible" significance, in accordance with recognised EIA methodology and applying professional judgement.

1.3 The "significance" of each effect takes into account both its "magnitude" and the "sensitivity" of the receptor affected. For example, a change of "large" magnitude affecting a receptor of "high" sensitivity would generally result in an effect of "major" significance. Conversely, a change of "small" magnitude affecting a receptor of "low" sensitivity would generally result in an effect of "minor" significance.

1.4 The full findings of this EIA are reported in the Environmental Statement (ES) dated October 2013 and Envionmental Statement Further Information Submission dated April 2016. The ES is available on Swindon Borough Council's website and can also be obtained on request from:

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1.5 This concise document summarises the main findings of the ES in non-technical language, for a wide readership.

1.6 The ES supports an Outline Planning Application (OPA) to Swindon Borough Council for the Proposed Development. Comments on it should therefore be directed to Swindon Borough Council, as part of its consideration of the OPA.

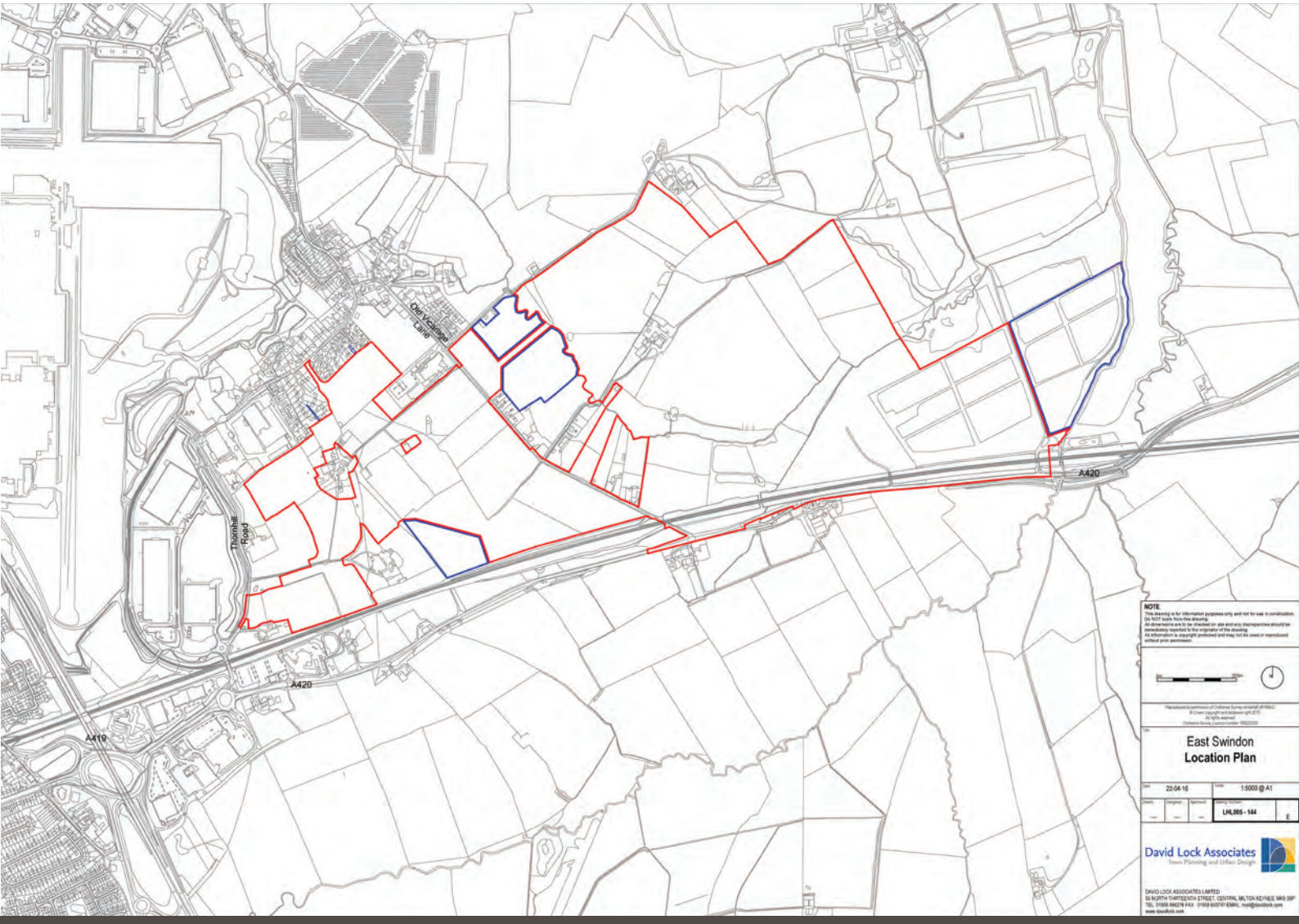

Fig 001 : Site Location Plan

02 The Site and the Proposed Development

2.1 The Application Site extends to some 153 hectares (378 acres) to the east of Swindon, south of South Marston village and extending east to Rowborough Farm, across Old Vicarage Lane. In general terms, the Site is bounded by the village of South Marston to the north, the Thornhill Road and Thornhill Industrial Estate to the west, the Great Western mainline railway to the south and agricultural field boundaries to the east.

2.2 The Site comprises agricultural land, including a well defined pattern of small and larger sized fields and hedgerows, and a number of agricultural buildings associated with Rowborough Farm. The topography is generally flat but the higher part of the Site is at Nightingale Wood to the east, gently falling in a south easterly direction towards the South Marston Brook and the River Cole.

2.3 The Proposed Development comprises, in summary:

- up to 2,380 new homes;
- up to 1,500 sqm (16,146 sqft) of business floorspace;
- floorspace for local shops (up to 1,500 sqm or 6,146 sqft) and for other local services;
- two-form entry (420-place) primary school, and one-form entry (210-place) school;
- community and sport buildings;
- sheltered residential accommodation;
- green infrastructure including sports pitches, informal open space and landscaped areas, and children's play areas;
- sustainable urban drainage systems (SuDS), including flood attenuation basins and drainage channels;
- connections to the surrounding highway, footpath, cycleway and bridleway networks;
- infrastructure and utilities provision, including car parking; and
- ground remodelling, engineering works and demolition within the site.

2.4 The Proposed Development comprises of two parts, being the growth of South Marston and to the east, a development of a new neighbouring community at Rowborough. Each area will have its own distinct identity and a strong landscape and green infrastructure framework will define and shape the development of South Marston and Rowborough as individual settlements. Particular emphasis has been placed on protecting South Marston from potential undesirable effects of growth.

2.5 A 12 year construction period is assumed in the EIA, extending from 2016 until 2028. A Construction Environmental Management Plan (CEMP), which would be agreed with Swindon Borough Council, would minimise environmental impacts during this period.

2.6 The Proposed Development is being brought forward as the first phase of the New Eastern Villages (NEV) development proposed by Swindon Borough Council in its new Local Plan (see para. 3.1 below). Potential alternative locations for that first phase of the NEV, to the south of the A420, have been rejected in view of their lesser scope to utilise existing infrastructure in serving new development.

2.7 Outline Planning Permission is sought at this stage. Detailed design is reserved for later agreement by Swindon Borough Council.

2.8 The following Development Framework Plan has formed the basis for the EIA. The detailed design of the Proposed Development would be in accordance with this overarching development framework. This conformity would be secured by appropriate conditions attached to any grant of Outline Planning Permission.

Fig 002 : Development Framework Plan

03 Planning Policy Context

3.1 The Proposed Development is being brought forward against a backdrop of support for high quality, well conceived development proposals in the Government's National Planning Policy Framework (NPPF), as well as the proposed allocation of the Site for the first phase of the NEV in the Swindon Borough Local Plan (2026), adopted in March 2015.

04 Socio-Economic Effects

4.1 No significant adverse socio-economic effects are predicted, taking into account the timely provision of supporting facilities as the development is built out. That timely provision would be secured by conditions and legal obligations attached to any grant of Outline Planning Permission.

4.2 Moderate beneficial effects on the local economy are predicted. Around 250 construction jobs each year would be generated, over the assumed 12 year construction period. Up to a further 300 or so jobs would be induced each year in the wider area by this construction activity.

4.3 Following the completion of the Proposed Development, some 292 jobs could be permanently accommodated within it, predominantly within the two proposed mixed use centres (see the Development Framework Plan). A further 188 or so jobs would be permanently induced in the locality as a result of the Proposed Development.

4.4 Less quantifiable, but major beneficial effects on the local housing market and on open space provision are assessed. Moderate beneficial effects on education provision, healthcare and community facility provision are also predicted, again taking into account the timely provision of the proposed primary school, public open space and community pavilion as the development is built out.

05 Transport

5.1 Construction of the Proposed Development is predicted to result in a maximum of around 150 two-way daily vehicle movements. Of those, around 20 are estimated to be HGV movements. The HGV movements would be scheduled to avoid rush hour periods, such that the construction of the Proposed Development would not have a discernible effect on traffic conditions in the area. Furthermore, construction traffic would be routed to avoid unsuitable roads in the area. Further mitigation would be provided through the Construction Environmental Management Plan (CEMP) (para. 2.5).

5.2 The intention of the access strategy for the Proposed Development is to maintain the A420 as the primary east-west corridor and providing direct and ready connection to the A420 at Thornhill Road, Old Vicarage Lane, and from the new access towards the eastern end of the development thereby minimising the traffic routing through the proposed development and the existing South Marston village. Improvements are proposed to the connections with the A420 at Old Vicarage Lane and Gablecross roundabout.

5.3 The selection of a roundabout junction on Thornhill Road provides a direct link into the development to reduce any need to travel through South Marston. The access into the development from Old Vicarage Lane includes the alteration of the priority such that traffic is discouraged from South Marston.

5.4 Consideration has also been given to the wider objectives in relation to transport set out in the Draft South Marston SPD. Public transport services are proposed to be improved. The objective of a 20 MPH speed limit throughout the village is supported in principle and in practice through the subsequent design of most streets within the development areas in accordance with such speeds. Rowborough and Nightingale Lanes are retained.

5.5 The Proposed Development would inevitably result in traffic increases on the southern sections of Thornhill Road and Old Vicarage Lane, from the access points into the development down to the A420. However, traffic levels on the sections of those roads between the access points to the Proposed Development and South Marston village would generally reduce at rush hour times. This is because the design of those access junctions would discourage traffic movements to the north, while some existing users of Thornhill Road and Old Vicarage Lane would be likely to divert to other routes rather than negotiate the additional junctions resulting from the Proposed Development.

5.6 The traffic modelling work confirms that traffic generated from within Rowborough will employ the access(es) to the A420 to the south rather than find its way to Thornhill Road and Gablecross roundabout via Thornhill Road. The proposed link between Old Vicarage Lane and Thornhill Road is therefore demonstrated not to form a southern bypass role for the South Marston area. Indeed the link has been designed with Manual for Streets philosophy in mind and will be experienced as a street within the landscape setting. The modelling further confirms that with the improvements proposed, the highway junctions in the immediate environs of the development will operate satisfactorily following development.

5.7 More generally, the likely impact of the Proposed Development on traffic conditions in South Marston, including at Pound Corner, has been fully appraised. This assessment indicates that the Proposed Development would not materially increase traffic flows through the village or impede access to the wider road network for existing residents, taking into account the improvement proposed to junctions on the A420 and for the reasons set out above.

5.8 The detailed traffic modelling undertaken has also taken account of further development resulting from the wider growth proposals to the east of Swindon, both committed and identified in the Local Plan. As would be expected, this work has identified further transport mitigation measures that would be necessary to deliver that wider growth. However, the assessments demonstrate that the delivery of this Phase 1 element of the NEV would not prejudice the delivery of any subsequent phases.

5.9 The Proposed Development includes new pedestrian and cycle routes connecting with the existing walking and cycling networks in the area, as well as providing for the extension of bus services into the Site. A key component of the transport mitigation measures is the implementation of a comprehensive Travel Plan, which proposes a target to reduce the mode share of single occupancy vehicles by 10%.

5.10 Overall, the proposed new transport infrastructure detailed in the Transport Assessment and the measures set out in the Travel Plan Framework would ensure no significant residual adverse effects on transport conditions would arise from the Proposed Development.

06 Air Quality

6.1 Application of measures within the proposed CEMP (see para. 2.4 above) would ensure impacts on local air quality during construction, including dust generation, would be of no greater than negligible significance.

6.2 Following completion, the Proposed Development is predicted to result in negligible effects on pollutant levels in the area.

07 Noise and Vibration

7.1 Application of measures within the proposed CEMP (see para. 2.5 above) would limit effects arising from noise and vibration during construction to minor adverse levels.

7.2 Following completion, the Proposed Development is expected to give rise to no more than negligible effects, both in terms of traffic noise in the wider area and noise levels experienced within the Proposed Development. Standard double glazing and passive ventilation measures (enabling windows to remain shut) would be required for residential properties near the railway line and the A420.

08 Landscape and Visual Effects

8.1 Major-moderate adverse effects on visual amenity are predicted in a number of areas during the construction phase: the public bridleway - public footpath near Rowborough Farm (viewpoint 3), residential properties on Old Vicarage Lane (viewpoint 4), the public bridleway near the Mercure Hotel (viewpoint 5), the footpath near South Marston Brook (viewpoint 6) and the bridleways on the edge of Nightingale Wood (viewpoints 10, 11 and 12).

8.2 The Proposed Development includes an extensive "Green Infrastructure Framework" comprising some 40% of the site (para. 2.3), which has been designed to minimise adverse visual effects on these and other receptors through, for example, by providing a setting for the built development and the provision of new woodland, hedgerow and tree planting which will deliver landscape, biodiversity and recreational enhancements. The GIF retains much of site's vegetation.

8.3 The visual effects of the Proposed Development would be limited to impacts upon localised receptors that are either within or close to the Site. Even in these locations, however, the significance of those effects is predicted to reduce to moderate adverse levels from completion of the Proposed Development; and then to minor adverse levels from fifteen years after its completion, as the proposed structural planting reaches maturity and people become accustomed to seeing the built development within its context.

8.4 During construction, effects on landscape character would be limited to the local landscape of the Site itself and its immediate environs. As a result of the Site's relative containment from the wider landscape, those effects are considered to be no greater than moderate adverse.

8.5 At Year 1 (following completion), the effects of the Proposed Development on landscape character would be moderate adverse. Those effects would diminish between Years 1 and 15, as the extensive Green Infrastructure Framework covering around 67 hectares or some 166 acres (over 40%) of the Site becomes established and delivers landscape and ecological benefits. By Year 15 following completion of the Proposed Development, its effects on landscape character are assessed as minor adverse-negligible.

09 Ecology and Biodiversity

9.1 Turning to ecological impacts, a minor adverse effect is predicted to arise from the loss of a small proportion of the overall hedgerow resource within the Site. This minor adverse effect should be considered in the context of the overall long term enhancements of grassland, scrub, hedgerow and woodland habitats that would result from the Proposed Development including as part of the extensive Green Infrastructure network.

9.2 No effects on any other species or habitats of greater than minor adverse significance are predicted.

10 Historic Environment

10.1 Moderate adverse effects are reported on two designated heritage assets; these are Manor Farm and The Red House, both Grade II listed buildings, and Rowborough (non-designated) whose current open rural settings would be affected. The Proposed Development has, however, been designed to respect the settings of these assets, including through proposed landscaping in these areas.

10.2 The Proposed Development has been designed to enable the preservation in situ of the majority of the area interpreted as a late prehistoric/Roman settlement between Manor and South Marston Farms. Other areas of archaeological features include to the west of Manor Farm and south of Nightingale Lane.

10.3 A programme of mitigation will be required comprising a programme of archaeological evaluation, and where necessary and/or appropriate, excavation and recording of any archaeological remains. Following appropriate mitigation there would be no residual adverse effects on these non-designated heritage assets.

11 Agriculture and Soil Resources

11.1 The Proposed Development would result in the loss of some 37 hectares (91 acres) of land in grade 2 or sub-grade 3a, which is within the "best and most versatile" category of agricultural land quality (grades 1 – 3a); and some 94 hectares of agricultural land graded 3b, which is of lower quality than the "best and most versatile" land. These losses are assessed as a minor adverse effect.

11.2 The re-use of topsoil within the Proposed Development and the application of standard measures to protect soil within landscaped and open areas would limit effects on the Site's soil resources to no greater than minor adverse levels of significance.

12 Water Resources

12.1 Taking account of standard environmental protection measures (including those to be applied through the CEMP; para. 2.5) and of the requirement to upgrade local foul sewerage and water supply capacity to serve the Proposed Development, its effects on water resources would be negligible.

12.2 The Proposed Development has been designed to limit surface water run-off from the Site to significantly below the baseline rate, resulting in negligible effects on flood risk both within and surrounding the Site.

13 Ground Conditions

13.1 Taking account of standard environmental protection measures (including those to be applied through the CEMP; para. 2.5), the effects of the Proposed Development on ground conditions would also be negligible.

14 Utilities

14.1 Taking account of standard environmental protection measures to be applied through the CEMP (para. 2.5), as well as careful planning and execution of required supply reinforcements and diversions of existing utility infrastructure, no greater than negligible effects are predicted.

15 Waste

15.1 A range of measures would be applied to minimise the generation of waste, maximise its re-use and recycling, and minimise the requirement for its disposal. During construction, the required Site Waste Management Plan would work in tandem with the CEMP to achieve these objectives. At occupation stage, a range of mitigation measures is proposed, including the provision of facilities for recycling and composting and the delivery of information to increase awareness of those facilities. As a result, no greater than negligible effects are predicted.

16 Conclusion

16.1 Residual (post-mitigation) effects of more than minor significance would be limited to three areas: socio-economic impacts; landscape and visual effects; and the historic environment.

16.2 Socio-economic effects would be beneficial (see section 4 above).

16.3 Moderate adverse landscape and visual effects are anticipated at the outset (Year 1), but these effects would reduce in the longer term upon maturity of the proposed structural planting to minor adverse-negligible landscape effects and minor adverse visual effects (see section 8 above). The proposals to include an extensive Green Infrastructure network comprising a substantial proportion of the site will deliver landscape, biodiversity and recreational enhancements and provide extensive areas for recreation. In conclusion the landscape effects as a result of the proposed development are not considered to be significant such that they would lead to unacceptable landscape harm.

16.4 Moderate adverse effects are reported on the significance of two designated heritage assets; these are Manor Farm and The Red House, both Grade II listed buildings, and one non-designated heritage asset, Rowborough farm.

16.5 No significant cumulative or interactive effects are anticipated to arise from the Proposed Development.

16.6 In overall terms, the outcome of the EIA is that significant beneficial effects are substantial, significant adverse ones are limited and beneficial effects outweigh adverse ones.

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